GAMING THE UNTHINKABLE

Four scenarios that could result in a nuclear holocaust in the subcontinent

Illustrations by **NILANJAN DAS / AI**



▶ SCENARIO 1

USE IT OR LOSE IT

CAUSE

- A decisive Indian strike across the LoC to capture PoK, or across the international border in Punjab and Rajasthan to threaten Pakistani cities
- Also, threat of overwhelming Pakistani defences, including tactical nuclear weapons stationed near the border

EFFECT

- For fear of conceding territory to India and/or its tactical weapons being captured, Pakistan strikes India with tactical nuclear weapons
- India launches a devastating nuclear counterattack



▶ SCENARIO 2

BOLT FROM THE BLUE

CAUSE

- In a limited war, in the one after Pahalgam, Indian air strikes inside Pakistani territory hit a road mobile dual-use missile launcher carrying a nuclear warhead, causing it to explode on Pakistani territory

EFFECT

- Pakistan sees it as deliberate nuclear escalation by India and responds with a debilitating nuclear counterattack. India responds by nuking major Pakistan cities

The Tipping Point

Experts in the know say that on May 10 between 2.30 am and 10.30 am—for eight hours, that is—the fate of the subcontinent hung in the balance. Brig. Feroz Hassan Khan (retd), a research professor at the US Naval Postgraduate School in Monterey, California, who had earlier served in Pakistan's Strategic Plans Division, says, "The fact that Nur Khan was hit [near] the capital city would create more political pressure. Both India and Pakistan had climbed the rungs of the military escalation ladder so fast, it was evident that in the next 24-48 hours, the tipping point would have been reached for an all-out war." That India had hit at strategic air bases such as Nur Khan, and Mushaf at Sargodha, meant that red lines were about to be crossed. "Had India inadvertently hit a nuclear storage site, Pakistan would have considered it as a first strike and retaliated with nuclear weapons. If the ceasefire had not been called on May 10, the next night would have been a terrible one," says Khan.

Tellis is among those who do not think the crisis was near nuclear boiling point. He believes the Indian air strikes of May 10 were extremely modest because, he says, "The fear of nuclear escalation is always baked into such conflicts. Destroying infrastructure is not something you can do in a single spasm of violence, it needs protracted targeting. In Nur Khan, India didn't set out to decapitate the nuclear command system. What they did was more of a psychological campaign of uncertainty, intimidation and fear, which is the real payoff rather